on politics that were banned in Yugoslavia, and printed by ethnic Slovenian publishing houses in Italy and Austria, or by political exiles in the USA or Argentina, were often hidden in the boxes of washing powder that were brought back across the borders on shopping expeditions. In other words, Slovenians were looking for all those artefacts of material, cultural and spiritual normality that their fathers and grandfathers knew in earlier times. The re-emergence of democracy and independence in the 1990s, and the accession to the European Union in 2004, therefore, represented a return to the normality of previous generations, not a venture into entirely uncharted territory. While other countries of the former Communist bloc were not as lucky in terms of travel abroad, the desire for such artefacts of normality was the same, even if they did not have the same opportunity to indulge in it. They still had the possibility of listening to short-wave BBC radio programmes (where Karl and Dora worked), to German Deutsche Welle or the Voice of America. I myself have warm childhood memories of the Slovenian ethnic minority radio programme from Trieste/Trst. By the way, these foreign stations also received considerable attention from the Yugoslav secret services, above all those young people posted to them as interns from Yugoslavia.

The other very important aspect of the open Yugoslav border was trade. Slovenia, the only Yugoslav republic bordering Western Europe, which had a relatively strong industrial tradition from the time of the Austro-Hungarian Empire, benefitted the most. It became the greatest Yugoslav exporter and the richest Yugoslav republic – and probably also the wealthiest nation in the whole Communist world. It was precisely because of the opening of the borders and the slightly less rigid Yugoslav economic system that we left Czechoslovakia economically behind during the post-war period. After 1990, Slovenia suddenly emerged as the richest of all the new independent states.

Returning to the subject of shopping abroad, Trieste/Trst, once frightened by the prospects of being taken over by Tito, thus became a consumer Mecca for Yugoslavs. This city, tucked in a short stretch of Italian territory under the Kras plateau, started to make a good living out of Yugoslav shoppers. For those on a budget, there was a particular part of the Trieste/Trst centre, around the old marina, where every imaginable type of Asian-made cheap good was on sale. The place, called Ponterosso, attracted